Mergesort

Divide, sort, merge – the N log N sort

Marcus Birkenkrahe

COSC 2230 · CS III · Augustana University

Fall 2026

By the end you can

1. explain mergesort: divide, sort each half recursively, merge
2. implement `merge()` with an auxiliary array and trace it with `i`, `j`, `k`
3. implement the recursive `sort(a, lo, hi)` and trace its calls
4. argue that mergesort is correct
5. derive its cost: $2N \lg N$ data moves, $\frac{1}{2} N \lg N$ to $N \lg N$ compares
6. confirm $N \log N$ growth with a doubling test – mergesort scales
7. name its price, an extra array, and reduce other problems to sorting

1,000 exam papers, two friends

How do you split the work?

Each friend sorts half – then you merge

Look at the top paper of each sorted pile, take the one that comes first, repeat.

With insertion sort, how long does half the pile take? → A quarter of the time: $(N/2)^2 = N^2/4$.
→ Two halves: half the time. Merging: one look per paper.

Now do the same for each half again, and again . . .

Mergesort: the idea

- **Divide** the array into two halves
- **Sort** each half – recursively
- **Merge** the two sorted halves into a sorted whole
- Base case: 0 or 1 entries are sorted
- **Divide-and-conquer**: independent parts, solved independently, then combined

input

```
was had him and | you his the but
```

sort left, sort right

```
and had him was | but his the you
```

merge

```
and but had him his the was you
```

John von Neumann (1903–1957) wrote mergesort in 1945, to test a new computer on a task other than numerical calculation.

Merging needs an extra array

- Merging two sorted halves inside the same array (**in place**) is very hard
- So `merge()` writes into an **auxiliary array** `aux[]` – and copies it back
- From outside it looks as if the merge happened in place
- The price: an extra array of size N (quicksort and heapsort sort in place – COSC 3210)

Half-open intervals, as in binary search

`a[lo, mid)` = `a[lo]` ... `a[mid-1]` `a[mid, hi)` = `a[mid]` ... `a[hi-1]`

Code-along 1: `Merge.java` in five steps

`Merge.java`

1	`private static String[] aux;`	the extra array
2	`merge(a, lo, mid, hi)`	fill aux[0, N), copy back
3	`sort(a)`	allocate aux once, start
4	`sort(a, lo, hi)`	base case, two calls, merge
5	`main()`	test client from Insertion

merge: two sorted halves
had was | and him
→ and had him was

sort: split, sort each half, merge
first run after step 5

```
$ java Merge < names16.txt   →   alice bob carlos . . . wendy
```

Later: `TestMerge.java` – the doubling test from `TestInsertion`, with `Merge.sort(a)`

Merge: merge()

→ **Switch to editor · code-along 1**

1. Create **`Merge.java`** with a static field **`String[] aux`**
2. Write **`merge(a, lo, mid, hi)`**: fill `aux[0, N)`, copy back

data: `birkenkrahe.github.io/data/names16.txt` · classpath: `.:stdlib.jar`

merge(): one index per half, one into aux[]

```
private static String[] aux;
public static void merge(String[] a,
                         int lo, int mid, int hi)
{
    int i = lo, j = mid, N = hi - lo;
    for (int k = 0; k < N; k++)
    {
        if      (i == mid) aux[k] = a[j++];
        else if (j == hi)  aux[k] = a[i++];
        else if (a[j].compareTo(a[i]) < 0)
                           aux[k] = a[j++];
        else               aux[k] = a[i++];
    }
    for (int k = 0; k < N; k++)
        a[lo + k] = aux[k];
}
```

- i: left half
- j: right half
- k: next free place in aux
- left used up: take right
- right used up: take left
- else the smaller one
- then copy back

Trace: one merge, one row per step

			left half a[0, 4)				right half a[4, 8)				
i	j	k	a[0]	a[1]	a[2]	a[3]	a[4]	a[5]	a[6]	a[7]	aux[k]
0	4	0	**and**	had	him	was	**but**	his	the	you	and
1	4	1	and	**had**	him	was	**but**	his	the	you	but
1	5	2	and	**had**	him	was	but	**his**	the	you	had
2	5	3	and	had	**him**	was	but	**his**	the	you	him
3	5	4	and	had	him	**was**	but	**his**	the	you	his
3	6	5	and	had	him	**was**	but	his	**the**	you	the
3	7	6	and	had	him	**was**	but	his	the	**you**	was
4	7	7	and	had	him	was	but	his	the	**you**	you

bold: a[i] and a[j], compared **teal**: taken into aux[k] grey: already in aux

How many compares? → 7: none in the last row – the left half is used up.
How many data moves? → 8 into aux, 8 back: $2N = 16$.

companion card 1: birkenkrahe.github.io/demos/merge-sort.html

Warm-up: trace one merge

WARM-UP · 5 MIN · CLOSED BOOK

`merge(a, 0, 4, 8)` merges the two sorted halves:

```
carol eve oscar wendy   |  bob dave frank peggy
```

1. One row per step: **i, j, k** and the entry that goes into `aux[k]`
2. Count the **compares**

Which case of `merge()` takes the last entry?

Solution

i	j	k	aux[k]
0	4	0	bob
0	5	1	carol
1	5	2	dave
1	6	3	eve
2	6	4	frank
2	7	5	oscar
3	7	6	peggy
3	8	7	wendy

- The halves alternate: 7 compares, one for every entry but the last
- After peggy, `j == hi`: the **right** half is used up, and wendy goes over without a compare
- In the class example the **left** half ran out first

Merge: `sort()` and the test client

→ **Switch to editor · code-along 1**

3. Write **`sort(a)`**: allocate aux once, call `sort(a, 0, a.length)`
4. Write **`sort(a, lo, hi)`**: base case, `mid`, two calls, merge
5. Test client: the one from `Insertion` – run it on **`names16.txt`**

data: `birkenkrahe.github.io/data/names16.txt` · classpath: `.:stdlib.jar`

sort(): allocate once, recurse

```
public static void sort(String[] a)
{
    aux = new String[a.length];
    sort(a, 0, a.length);
}

public static void sort(String[] a,
                        int lo, int hi)
{
    int N = hi - lo;
    if (N <= 1) return;
    int mid = lo + N/2;
    sort(a, lo, mid);
    sort(a, mid, hi);
    merge(a, lo, mid, hi);
}
```

```
$ java Merge < names16.txt
alice bob carlos carol craig
dave erin eve frank oscar
peggy trent trudy victor
walter wendy
```

aux is a field: `null` until `sort(a)` assigns it. With `String[] aux = ...` in `sort(a)`, a local variable hides the field, and the first `merge()` throws a **`NullPointerException`**.

The same algorithm works for `Comparable[]`, with aux passed as a parameter.

Overloading: same name, different parameters

- Two methods named `sort()`: Java picks the one whose parameters match – as with `StdOut.println()`
- You know the pattern: `sumAcc(n)` calls the **private** helper `sumAcc(n, acc)`, which is only correct when `acc` starts at 0
- Same name **and** same parameter types: not allowed

```
$ javac -cp .:stdlib.jar Merge.java
error: method sort(String[],int,int) is already defined in class Merge
```

Code-along: paste a second copy of `sort(a, lo, hi)` into `Merge.java`, compile, delete it

Questions about the code

Why allocate `aux` in `sort(a)`, not in `merge()`?
→ $N - 1$ merges × a new array of length N: about N^2 steps.

Why `< 0` and not `<= 0`?
→ On a tie the left entry goes first: equal keys keep their order (**stable**).

What happens without `if (N <= 1) return;`?
→ `sort(a, lo, lo+1)` calls itself again: `StackOverflowError`.

Why check `i == mid` and `j == hi` first?
→ A used-up half has no entry to compare: `a[hi]` may be outside the array.

companion card 1, "equal keys": `birkenkrahe.github.io/demos/merge-sort.html`

Trace: the calls of `sort()`

	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
	was	had	him	and	you	his	the	but
`sort(a, 0, 8)`								
`sort(a, 0, 4)`								
`sort(a, 0, 2)`	had	was	him	and	you	his	the	but
`sort(a, 2, 4)`	had	was	and	him	you	his	the	but
`merge 0..4`	and	had	him	was	you	his	the	but
`sort(a, 4, 8)`								
`sort(a, 4, 6)`	and	had	him	was	his	you	the	but
`sort(a, 6, 8)`	and	had	him	was	his	you	but	the
`merge 4..8`	and	had	him	was	but	his	the	you
`merge 0..8`	and	but	had	him	his	the	was	you

How deep does the recursion get for 8 entries? For a million? → 8, 4, 2, 1: 4 calls. A million: $\lg 10^6 + 1 \approx 21$.

Rows: the array after a call returns (sizes 0 and 1 not shown)

companion card 2: `birkenkrahe.github.io/demos/merge-sort.html`

Correctness: the three pieces

Piece	Guarantees	In `Merge.sort(a, lo, hi)`
base case	smallest cases right	$N \leq 1$: 0 or 1 entries are sorted
termination	an answer is reached	both halves are smaller than N
reduction	the answer is right	two sorted halves $\rightarrow$ `merge()` $\rightarrow$ sorted

Why `merge()` is right

Before each step, `aux[0, k)` holds the k smallest entries of both halves, in order. The next smallest is the smaller of `a[i]` and `a[j]`.

Odd N: `mid = lo + N/2` rounds down – the left half has one entry fewer ($N = 11$: 5 and 6).

companion card 2, "11 names (odd N)": `birkenkrahe.github.io/demos/merge-sort.html`

Practice: count the compares

PRACTICE · 5 MIN · CLOSED BOOK

Merge the two sorted halves with `merge()`:

(a)	alice	bob	carol	dave	erin	eve	frank	oscar
(b)	alice	carol	erin	frank	bob	dave	eve	oscar

1. Write the names in the order they go into `aux[]`
2. Count the **compares** of each merge

Same 8 names, same data moves. Why a different number of compares?

Solution

(a)

halves	alice	bob	carol	dave	erin	eve	frank	oscar	
aux[]	alice	bob	carol	dave	erin	eve	frank	oscar	
compares	1	1	1	1	–	–	–	–	**4**

`alice` to `dave` each win against `erin`; then the left half is used up (`i == mid`), and the rest goes over without a compare.

(b)

halves	alice	carol	erin	frank	bob	dave	eve	oscar	
aux[]	alice	bob	carol	dave	erin	eve	frank	oscar	
compares	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	–	**7**

The halves alternate: one compare for every name but the last.

Data moves: 16 in both, 8 into aux and 8 back.
One merge of N entries: between $N/2$ and $N - 1$ compares.

blue: left half amber: right half